



**jesse
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Tanner Has Pirates Aimed Toward Peak

Pittsburgh Manager Chuck Tanner and I go back a long way, all the way to 1951 when he was an outfielder with the Atlanta Crackers in the Southern Association.

Reminiscing in the Pirate clubhouse before Friday night's game at the Stadium, I asked him what has changed most in baseball during his 33-year career.

"Money," said Tanner, smiling. "When I signed with the Boston Braves in 1946, they gave me a \$3,000 bonus and sent me to Owensboro, Ky., in the Three-I League. My salary was \$135 monthly, and we got a dollar-a-day meal money on the road. The team didn't rent many rooms. They put four guys in each room."

Clubhouse custodian Mark Gladulich strolled into the manager's office to inform Tanner that Phil Niekro was pitching against the Pirates in the series opener.

"Tell Knuckie to get a job and go to work," said Tanner. "I used to hit against him and I've been managing now for 17 years. What a remarkable pitcher he is. It's too bad he didn't get named to the All-Star team, for he's certainly an All-Star every year. We beat Joe Niekro Thursday night in Houston to sweep three games from the Astros."

"We're going good now," Tanner continued, "and our guys think we're going to win it. Certainly, I'm not going to do anything to change their minds. Getting Bill Madlock from the Giants has helped us. Of course, we've got the power, but injuries to our pitchers have hurt. I haven't been able to make a complete rotation of the pitching staff since the season started. We've had only 10 complete games, but Kent Tekulve, Enrique Romo and Grant Jackson have done a great job in the bullpen."

Parker Is Better Later

I mentioned that Dave Parker hasn't hit his peak this season.

"He's having what would be an outstanding year for anyone else," said Tanner. "He's hitting over .300 and has knocked in more than 50 runs. If you'll check, you'll find out that he was going about the same pace last year. He always gets better in the second half."

The Pirates were runners-up to the Phillies in NL East the past two seasons, and Tanner has now finished second four times in eight previous years as a major league manager.

"I think we are going to win the pennant," said Tanner, "but we're in a tough division. Montreal has been out front, but I look for Philadelphia to make a move, and Chicago is for real. I look for a race right to the wire like last year."

Tanner is one of the most personable guys you'll encounter in any profession, and he has an exceptional knack of communicating with his players. He played for 15 managers during his lengthy career, and I inquired what manager influenced him most.

"I like to think I learned a lot from Charlie Grimm. Fred Haney, Gene March, Dixie Walker and Andy Cohen, to mention a few," he said, "but I'd say that Whitlow Wyatt influenced me the most. Next to talent, I think attitude is the most important thing in baseball, and Wyatt handled players on the 1954 pennant team in Atlanta better than any manager I've seen."

Learn In Minors

"Managing in the minors eight seasons was great experience," he said. "You have to learn in the minors. First five years I managed. I didn't even have a coach. I pitched batting practice, handed out meal money, and even drove the bus on occasion."

Tanner was a solid ballplayer, but he never achieved star status in the majors. I wondered what was the most money he made as a player.

"I had a pretty good year with the Cubs in 1957," he said. "Next season I got a \$3,000 raise to \$15,000. I never could afford an agent."

I asked if today's wealthy players are more difficult to manage.

"Not at all," Tanner said. "Once you get on the field, it doesn't matter what you make. I think the most important role of a manager is promoting the proper attitude on a team. It's easy when you're winning, but a manager has to try and keep the team up when it's losing."

"I mean it sincerely when I say that, in 17 seasons as a manager, I've never managed what I consider a bad guy. By a bad guy, I mean one who doesn't try during a game. Of course, I've had several who didn't fit into our scheme of thinking. Life is too short to reform them. People don't change. They just change clubs."

Chuck Tanner hasn't changed in all the years I've known him. But he's come a long way from the dollar-a-day meal money to his large suite at the Marriott and other hotels around the National League.